On

a warm afternoon in Mubarakpur, near IIM Lucknow, the faint scent of lemongrass mingles with the earthy smell of drying leaves. Inside a two-storey building, women in crisp hairnets and gloves move in a quiet rhythm—weighing powders, sealing soaps, sliding green tea pouches into neat stacks. Along one wall, rows of jars and packets gleam in shades of green, each tagged with a name and batch date. Almost all of it traces back to a single, unassuming tree that has quietly gone global: moringa.

Also known as the drumstick tree, moringa is a hardy, fast-growing plant long used in Indian kitchens. In recent years, it has been crowned a "superfood" abroad, thanks to its dense load of protein, vitamins, minerals and antioxidants. Nearly every part of the plant—leaves, pods, seeds—is edible or medicinal. What's more, it thrives in poor soil with little water.

For Dr Kamini Singh, moringa opened up a green highway. It became the cornerstone of Doctor Moringa. Starting with a Rs 9 lakh loan, it has flowered into an enterprise with an annual turnover of Rs 2 crore, a workforce spread across five states, and exports to Malaysia, Canada and the UAE.

Her journey began far from the factory floor. Raised in Banaras and later settled in Lucknow, Kamini worked as a senior research fellow at the Central Institute for Subtropical Horticulture (CISH), studying crops and working with farmers. By 2015, while pursuing a PhD, she left her post for personal reasons. Her desire to work directly with farmers gave birth to the Jaivik Vikas Krishi Sansthan in 2016. Its aim: to promote organic farming and boost rural livelihoods.

A chance visit to a nursery altered her path again. Neat rows of moringa trees stood there, largely ignored by commercial growers in the region. She knew their value and also the market gap. Convincing farmers to try it was another matter. They had never grown it and prices for organic produce barely covered costs at the time. She urged them to plant moringa along field boundaries, often returning from villages with nothing but polite refusals. But a few did agree.

In 2018, she leased seven acres in Sidhauli, about an hour's drive from Lucknow, and planted moringa with lemongrass as an intercrop. The harvest was generous—400 kg of leaves per acre—but there was no nearby buyer. Transporting fresh leaves made no sense. So, Kamini decided to go the whole hog and process them herself.

She approached IIT-BHU with her plan, secured a Rs 9 lakh loan, and set up a small unit to dry and powder the leaves, later pressing them into tablets. IIT-BHU also offered technical support and, later, a Rs 25 lakh grant. Then came COVID-19. As moringa's health benefits hit the headlines, demand surged. Her product range quickly expanded to teas, soaps, energy bars, mosquito repellent, and ready-to-eat snacks like moringa cookies and flavoured makhana (foxnuts).

Today, Doctor Moringa works with 1,050 farmers in Lucknow alone, 210 of them women. Across five states, over 5,000 people are involved in its farming, plucking and processing activities, across 200 acres. Exports make up 15 per cent of sales, and Kamini is now in talks with buyers in Argentina.

The hardest part, she says, was getting farmers to believe in a crop without an obvious market. Now, they come to her of their own volition. The company sells online, through its own app and in select stores.

The factory doors open onto a narrow lane, but Kamini is already looking far beyond it—to new farms, new products and new countries where her bright green powder might land. "Leaf farming and plucking is easy for women," she says, glancing across the busy workshop. "That is why we are promoting it." Moringa, for her, is a way to create work with dignity. ■

FACT SHEET

Name of company
Doctor Moringa

What they do
Engage 5,000 people in farming, plucking and processing moringa to produce a wide variety of products

Founded in
2019 (pilot project began in 2017)

Annual turnover
Rs 2 crore

> **"WE AIM TO MAKE MORINGA PART OF PEOPLE'S LIVES AND, AT THE SAME TIME, GIVE WOMEN MEANINGFUL WORK. LEAF FARMING AND PROCESSING FITS INTO THEIR DAILY ROUTINES AND BECOMES A SOURCE OF INCOME"**
>
> **DR KAMINI SINGH**